

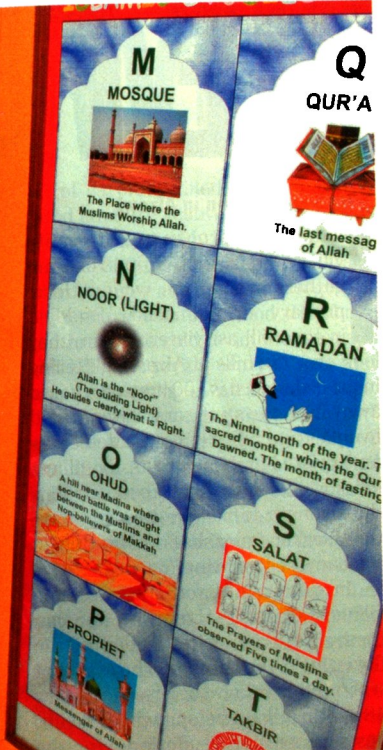
BABY STEPS: Pre-schoolers at the Al Jamiatul Fikriya English School

come more employable. "We call these 'forward schools' since we believe that an English education coupled with Islamic values will take us forward in all spheres of life," says Shehnaz Shaikh, 42-year-old founder-principal of Al Muminah Girls' Islamic English School. "Education should address not only the mind and body, but also the heart and the soul of a child. Academic knowledge should never be presented to children in a moral vacuum. Allah should always be a part of the lesson," says Shehnaz.

This happy mix of tradition and modernity has encouraged even conservatives to enroll their children in these English-medium schools. They are recognised by the Maharashtra state board, CISCE (Council for Indian School Certificate Examinations) and CBSE (Central Board of Secondary Education). "All these schools have clearance from state and government boards," asserts Sharvari Gokhale, the state's chief secretary for education. Along with lessons on the Quran and the history of the Arabs, students also learn Hindi and Marathi, and skills like swimming,

karate and computers. Some schools forbid the use of television, while others encourage children to watch educational channels. Located in Muslim-dominated areas, some of these schools charge nominal fees while those administering the SSC (Secondary School Certificate) examinations charge fees ranging from Rs 50 to Rs 2,000 a month. Some institutions, conducting ICSE (Indian Certificate of Secondary Education) and IGCE (International General Certificate of Secondary Education) examinations, charge a monthly fee between Rs 2,000 and Rs 5,000.

"We are keen to produce a generation of true Muslims in looks and thought. We want to produce an Indian Muslim who will destroy the orthodox image prevailing of typical Muslims in the world," says 39-year-old Israt Shaikh, principal of Al Saffah Islamic English School. Israt took over the school's reins after she lost her husband in an accident and thanks her education for her success. If Muslims have at all resisted melding into the mainstream educational system, these schools are the answer, allowing students the freedom to be faithful as well as fearless. ■



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